

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Nature of Religious Language - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Nature of Religious Language

REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST

01

THE PROBLEM OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE

□ Fact: An ICML 2026 paper on Sanskrit-English translation reports

02

MEANING, REFERENCE AND TRANSCENDENCE

Technically, Meaning, Reference And Transcendence is analysed by

03

ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND NEGATIVE THEOLOGY

Two types: □ Analogy of attribution — "God is good" because God is

04

COGNITIVISM, NON-COGNITIVISM AND FALSIFICATION

Cognitivist (realist): religious statements are genuine truth-claims —

05

TILLICH, AQUINAS, VIA NEGATIVA AND LANGUAGE-GAMES

□ The strong answer: religious language is neither literal nor

06

ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND FOUNDATIONAL POSITIONS

□ Aquinas locates God-talk between univocal sameness and equivocal

07

INDIAN AND WESTERN STRATEGIES OF RELIGIOUS SPEECH

Technically, Indian And Western Strategies Of Religious Speech is

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Nature of Religious Language - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]	3
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	12

Nature of Religious Language - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed. across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

1. Which formulation best distinguishes the two main axes in the study of religious language?

A. HOW is cognitive; WHETHER is necessarily non-cognitive. B. HOW asks how transcendent predicates signify; WHETHER asks whether utterances are truth-apt. C. HOW concerns only ritual; WHETHER concerns only mysticism. D. HOW asks whether God exists; WHETHER asks which religion is oldest.

Answer: B. HOW asks how transcendent predicates signify; WHETHER asks whether utterances are truth-apt.

Explanation: Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.

2. Aquinas' analogy of proportionality most nearly means that:

A. "Good" has wholly unrelated meanings for God and creatures. B. goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs. C. divine goodness is only a metaphor generated by human emotion. D. God is called good only because believers choose a moral policy.

Answer: B. goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs.

Explanation: Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.

3. In Aquinas' account, what is the function of the distinction between *res significata* and *modus significandi*?

A. It denies that perfection-terms signify anything of God. B. It converts every divine predicate into a liturgical command. C. It makes God and creatures ontologically members of one genus. D. It permits the perfection signified to apply truly while treating the creaturely manner of signifying as inadequate.

Answer: D. It permits the perfection signified to apply truly while treating the creaturely manner of signifying as inadequate.

Explanation: The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.

4. Which statement accurately represents Duns Scotus' univocity?

A. God and creatures possess being in exactly the same ontological mode. B. The concept of being is semantically common, while finite and infinite intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference. C. "Being" is a genus containing God and creatures as species. D. Univocity is unnecessary for inference because analogy is wholly equivocal.

Answer: B. The concept of being is semantically common, while finite and infinite intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference.

Explanation: Scotus' certain-and-doubtful-concepts argument requires a neutral concept: one may be certain that God is a being while doubtful whether finite or infinite. This is conceptual univocity, not the claim that God and creatures exist in the same manner. Nor does Scotus place God in a genus.

5. Maimonides permits which form of discourse about God most characteristically?

A. Only univocal positive predicates shared with creatures. B. Purely fictional stories with no theological intent. C. Symbols understood as identical with their divine referent. D. Negations and attributes of action rather than positive essential attributes.

Answer: D. Negations and attributes of action rather than positive essential attributes.

Explanation: In *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.

6. What most decisively distinguishes a Tillichian symbol from a sign?

A. A symbol is always linguistic whereas a sign is always visual. B. A symbol has one fixed conventional meaning and cannot die. C. A symbol is merely an inaccurate literal statement. D. A symbol participates in what it indicates and opens levels of reality and self.

Answer: D. A symbol participates in what it indicates and opens levels of reality and self.

Explanation: A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.

7. Which is the safest account of Tillich's "being-itself" claim?

A. It is simply another conventional sign with no ontological role. B. It means God is the highest being within the universe. C. Tillich treated "God is being-itself" as a non-symbolic anchor, but later modified the position and its status remains disputed. D. Tillich consistently denied that any statement can function as a referential anchor.

Answer: C. Tillich treated "God is being-itself" as a non-symbolic anchor, but later modified the position and its status remains disputed.

Explanation: Tillich rejects God as one being among beings. The proposed exception seeks to prevent wholly symbolic theology from becoming referentially circular, yet it generates a self-reference problem and was not an untroubled, invariant doctrine. A top answer must preserve this caution.

8. Ian Ramsey's "model and qualifier" account explains religious language by claiming that:

A. qualifiers cancel all ordinary content. B. an ordinary model is stretched by a qualifier until a disclosure situation occurs. C. models are dispensable once a creed is memorised. D. religious models are univocal scientific descriptions.

Answer: B. an ordinary model is stretched by a qualifier until a disclosure situation occurs.

Explanation: "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.

9. Which religious utterance most clearly illustrates Austin's performative analysis?

A. "The manuscript contains five chapters," used bibliographically. B. "Some believers fast," used as a sociological description. C. "The temple was built of stone," used as an archaeological report. D. "I take refuge in the Buddha," sincerely uttered as an act of commitment.

Answer: D. "I take refuge in the Buddha," sincerely uttered as an act of commitment.

Explanation: The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a detached description is a category mistake.

10. Donald Evans' idea of self-involvement is best captured by which claim?

A. Their avowal characteristically implicates the speaker in attitudes, relationships and conduct. B. Religious utterances are always private sensations. C. Self-involvement proves that religious statements cannot assert anything. D. Only first-person sentences have religious meaning.

Answer: A. Their avowal characteristically implicates the speaker in attitudes, relationships and conduct.

Explanation: Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.

11. A. J. Ayer's challenge to "God exists" rests primarily on the claim that:

A. it is neither analytically true nor empirically verifiable and is therefore literally meaningless. B. it is false because evil exists. C. it is analogical rather than univocal. D. it expresses a morally admirable *blik*.

Answer: A. it is neither analytically true nor empirically verifiable and is therefore literally meaningless.

Explanation: Ayer's is hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.

12. Flew's invisible-gardener parable is designed to ask:

A. whether religious stories improve moral motivation. B. whether symbols arise from collective life. C. whether God can be named only negatively. D. what conceivable evidence could count against a religious assertion before qualifications empty it of content.

Answer: D. what conceivable evidence could count against a religious assertion before qualifications empty it of content.

Explanation: Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.

13. R. M. Hare's response to Flew uses bliks to describe:

A. basic, unfalsifiable ways of seeing the world that can still govern life significantly. B. empirically verified predictions about divine action. C. analogies grounded in causal participation. D. liturgical commands unique to Mīmāṃsā.

Answer: A. basic, unfalsifiable ways of seeing the world that can still govern life significantly.

Explanation: Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.

14. Why is Basil Mitchell's partisan and Stranger often regarded as more cognitivist than Hare's blik?

A. The partisan admits that contrary evidence counts against trust even while commitment survives it. B. The partisan possesses conclusive proof. C. The partisan treats faith only as a moral policy. D. The partisan denies any distinction between evidence and loyalty.

Answer: A. The partisan admits that contrary evidence counts against trust even while commitment survives it.

Explanation: Mitchell models **defeasible trust**: commitment can endure ambiguity without declaring all counterevidence irrelevant. This preserves vulnerability to reasons and therefore cognitive content better than an unfalsifiable *blik*, though the boundary between resilient trust and immunity remains delicate.

15. Hick's eschatological verification claims that a religious proposition may be:

A. meaningless now but meaningful after death. B. falsifiable now but never verifiable. C. truth-apt now and confirmable at the eschaton, despite lacking present decisive verification. D. only a symbol with no possible confirmation.

Answer: C. truth-apt now and confirmable at the eschaton, despite lacking present decisive verification.

Explanation: Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.

16. According to Braithwaite, "God is love" primarily functions as:

A. an analogy of attribution. B. a literal report of an observable divine property. C. a declaration of commitment to an agapeistic moral policy sustained by religious stories. D. a prediction verified at the end of history.

Answer: C. a declaration of commitment to an agapeistic moral policy sustained by religious stories.

Explanation: Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.

17. Which statement best reflects the Wittgensteinian approach to religious language?

A. Every religious claim is meaningless by verificationist criteria. B. Every religious sentence expresses the same agapeistic policy. C. Religious grammar is identical to laboratory reporting. D. Meaning should be sought in use within a religious language-game and form of life.

Answer: D. Meaning should be sought in use within a religious language-game and form of life.

Explanation: Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.

18. What qualification is required when discussing D. Z. Phillips?

A. He created Ayer's verification principle. B. He reduced all worship to fictionalism. C. He rejected being labelled a non-cognitivist or reductionist and presented his work as clarification of religious grammar. D. He defended Scotus' intrinsic modes.

Answer: C. He rejected being labelled a non-cognitivist or reductionist and presented his work as clarification of religious grammar.

Explanation: Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.

19. Which analysis best describes a mixed speech-act account?

A. Assertions and performatives can never coexist. B. Every religious utterance is only expressive. C. Cognitive content requires univocal literalism. D. Religious utterances may be assertoric, symbolic, expressive and commissive at once.

Answer: D. Religious utterances may be assertoric, symbolic, expressive and commissive at once.

Explanation: "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.

20. Which comparison between secular and religious language is most defensible?

A. They use completely different vocabularies. B. They share ordinary words, but often differ in function, referent, verification, register and self-involvement. C. Religious language violates all ordinary logic. D. Secular language is always descriptive and religious language always performative.

Answer: B. They share ordinary words, but often differ in function, referent, verification, register and self-involvement.

Explanation: Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.

21. In Advaita, *neti neti* primarily functions as:

A. a theory that *māyā* is absolutely unreal. B. the grammarian doctrine of a sentence-whole. C. univocal description of Brahman's properties. D. eliminative negation of limiting identifications, not denial that Brahman is real.

Answer: D. eliminative negation of limiting identifications, not denial that Brahman is real.

Explanation: *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.

22. What does bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā do in interpreting tat tvam asi?

A. It proves that *tat* and *tvam* are entirely equivocal. B. It retains every literal connotation of both terms. C. It discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness as the common import. D. It classifies Brahman as neither real nor unreal.

Answer: C. It discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness as the common import.

Explanation: Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.

23. Which distinction concerning anirvacanīyatā is correct?

A. Brahman and *māyā* are indescribable in exactly the same technical sense. B. *Anirvacanīyatā* means merely that evidence is temporarily unavailable. C. *Māyā* is *anirvacanīya* as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is real but beyond objectifying speech. D. Brahman is neither real nor unreal, whereas *māyā* is pure being.

Answer: C. Māyā is anirvacanīya as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is real but beyond objectifying speech.

Explanation: *Māyā* is *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*: experienced and transactionally valid, yet sublated by knowledge. Brahman is *sat* and ineffable/non-objectifiable, not indeterminate in the same ontological category. This is a frequent factual trap.

24. Which school-doctrine attribution is correct?

A. Mīmāṃsā teaches *sphoṭa* as its distinctive theory of sentence meaning. B. Mīmāṃsā stresses *vidhi* and *śabda-nityatva*, while *sphoṭa* belongs to grammarians such as Bhartṛhari. C. Grammarians teach *vidhi* as the Veda's primary injunctive function. D. Mīmāṃsā rejects the eternity of word-meaning relation.

Answer: B. Mīmāṃsā stresses vidhi and śabda-nityatva, while sphoṭa belongs to grammarians such as Bhartṛhari.

Explanation: Vedic injunction is performative/injunctive rather than merely descriptive, and mantra functions within ritual action. Attributing *sphoṭa* to Mīmāṃsā is a standard UPSC factual error; it is associated with the grammatical tradition.

25. The Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad offers a model of symbol leading beyond itself because:

A. it identifies *turīya* with one more empirical state. B. A-U-M maps waking, dream and deep sleep, while soundless *amātra* indicates *turīya* beyond articulated sound. C. it denies any connection between *Om* and consciousness. D. it treats sound as a literal material creator.

Answer: B. A-U-M maps waking, dream and deep sleep, while soundless amātra indicates turīya beyond articulated sound.

Explanation: The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.

26. Which is the strongest negative case against the claim that symbolism necessarily leads to mysticism?

A. Symbols never transform their users. B. Mysticism is always empirical verification. C. Symbols may arrest in idolatry, while constructivists argue that they constitute rather than precede mystical experience. D. *Neti neti* is itself a univocal symbol.

Answer: C. Symbols may arrest in idolatry, while constructivists argue that they constitute rather than precede mystical experience.

Explanation: Tillich's idolatry/demonic warning shows failed transcendence; Steven Katz challenges an unmediated terminus because experience is conceptually formed. Zen iconoclasm, *neti neti*, ethics and grace further show that symbols are neither sufficient nor necessary.

27. Ricoeur's dictum "the symbol gives rise to thought" is best used to show that:

A. symbols eliminate interpretation. B. symbols possess an interpretive surplus that can deepen reflection beyond literal reading. C. symbolic language is merely emotive. D. every symbol guarantees mystical union.

Answer: B. symbols possess an interpretive surplus that can deepen reflection beyond literal reading.

Explanation: Ricoeur's "second naïveté" permits post-critical re-inhabitation of symbolism. The symbol prompts thought and may support mystical movement, but no guarantee follows; it can also be criticised, transformed or exhausted.

28. Pseudo-Dionysius' sequence relevant to religious symbolism and mysticism is:

A. univocity -> proportionality -> attribution. B. verification -> falsification -> moral policy. C. cataphatic affirmation -> apophatic negation -> mystical unknowing. D. sign -> symbol -> ritual command.

Answer: C. cataphatic affirmation -> apophatic negation -> mystical unknowing.

Explanation: Creature-derived names are first affirmed, then stripped away, culminating in "darkness beyond light." The structure shows how symbolic or affirmative theology may educate and then yield to silence rather than remain literal.

29. Which statement best expresses the pluralism bridge in religious language?

A. Non-cognitive language makes inter-religious disagreement impossible. B. Analogical, symbolic or apophatic semantics can make rival descriptions partial and mode-relative, though not all contradictions disappear. C. Univocal literalism always proves all religions true. D. Pluralism follows automatically from any belief in God.

Answer: B. Analogical, symbolic or apophatic semantics can make rival descriptions partial and mode-relative, though not all contradictions disappear.

Explanation: Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.

30. Hick's "transcategorical Real" is fundamentally also a thesis about:

A. ritual chronology. B. the limits of applying substantial human predicates literally to ultimate reality. C. the empirical identity of all deities. D. the moral superiority of one tradition.

Answer: B. the limits of applying substantial human predicates literally to ultimate reality.

Explanation: Hick's *personae* and *impersonae* are phenomenal forms through which the Real is experienced. Remove the semantic limitation and the pluralist hypothesis loses its basis. The cost is the familiar apophatic objection: a Real with no substantial predicates risks emptiness.

31. Which Indian resource most directly marks standpoint-relativity inside propositions rather than merely declaring the ultimate unknowable?

A. Mīmāṃsā *vidhi*. B. Advaita *neti neti* alone. C. Grammarian *śpoṭa*. D. Jain *anekāntavāda* expressed through *syādvāda* and *saptabhaṅgī*.

Answer: D. Jain anekāntavāda expressed through syādvāda and saptabhaṅgī.

Explanation: The prefix *syāt* locates assertions "in a certain respect," enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.

32. Which claim about religious and secular speech acts is false?

A. Once an utterance is performative, it cannot possess any cognitive implications. B. Secular speech may also include promises and commands. C. A religious performative can carry assertoric presuppositions. D. Religious speech may include genuine assertions.

Answer: A. Once an utterance is performative, it cannot possess any cognitive implications.

Explanation: Speech-act categories describe force, not sealed semantic compartments. "I baptise" performs an act but presupposes beliefs about office, ritual and community. Mixed force is central to avoiding the false cognitive/non-cognitive binary.

33. For the PYQ directive "Discuss whether and how X leads to Y," the best answer strategy is to:

A. treat "whether" and "how" as synonymous. B. explain only the meaning of X. C. list thinkers without giving a verdict. D. answer whether, reconstruct the mechanism of how in stages, and include the negative case.

Answer: D. answer whether, reconstruct the mechanism of how in stages, and include the negative case.

Explanation: In the 2019 symbol-mysticism question, the “how” carries the main analytical burden. A high-scoring response must show participation, deepening, self-effacement and possible immediacy, then test necessity through idolatry, constructivism and alternative routes.

34. For “In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use?” the examiner principally expects:

A. specified axes such as function, referent, verification, logic and self-involvement. B. a list of sacred words. C. proof that religious language has no ordinary vocabulary. D. proof that secular language is exclusively factual.

Answer: A. specified axes such as function, referent, verification, logic and self-involvement.

Explanation: “In what sense” demands criteria of comparison. Austin, Evans and Ramsey explain functional difference while the continuity thesis prevents exaggeration: religion repurposes ordinary language and remains answerable to intelligibility and logic.

35. Which approach secures inference most directly but incurs the characteristic risk of anthropomorphism?

A. Complete equivocity. B. Maimonidean negation. C. Scotist semantic univocity, unless finite/infinite modes are carefully preserved. D. Hare’s *blik*.

Answer: C. Scotist semantic univocity, unless finite/infinite modes are carefully preserved.

Explanation: A common concept allows valid inference from creatures to God. Scotus answers the risk through intrinsic modes and denial that being is a genus, but critics still worry about placing Creator and creature within a common conceptual order.

36. Which trade-off is accurately stated?

A. Univocity risks anthropomorphism; analogy risks indeterminacy; negation risks vacuity. B. Univocity secures transcendence but destroys inference. C. Analogy eliminates all indeterminacy. D. Negation supplies the richest positive description.

Answer: A. Univocity risks anthropomorphism; analogy risks indeterminacy; negation risks vacuity.

Explanation: The three classical exits purchase different goods. A nuanced position may combine an analogical centre, enough semantic continuity for inference, and an apophatic limit on adequacy rather than treating one strategy as cost-free.

37. Which claim most accurately differentiates Braithwaite from Ayer?

A. Braithwaite preserves religious significance as moral commitment; Ayer declares unverifiable theology literally meaningless. B. Braithwaite is a literal realist; Ayer is an analogical realist. C. Both offer identical theories of *blinks*. D. Both ground meaning in a religious form of life.

Answer: A. Braithwaite preserves religious significance as moral commitment; Ayer declares unverifiable theology literally meaningless.

Explanation: Both are non-cognitive in different senses, but Braithwaite is constructive and conative, whereas Ayer is eliminative and verificationist. Lumping them together erases the philosophical issue UPSC repeatedly tests.

38. Which objection most directly targets Braithwaite’s moral-policy theory?

A. It treats symbols as participatory. B. It relies upon univocal predication. C. It makes religious stories too historically accurate. D. It cannot fully represent believers who intend to assert divine reality as well as commit morally.

Answer: D. It cannot fully represent believers who intend to assert divine reality as well as commit morally.

Explanation: This is the reductionism or intentional-adequacy objection. The theory also struggles to explain why specifically religious narratives should bind if their truth is irrelevant, and it cannot reduce the full range of prayer, lament and creation claims to agape.

39. Why does analogy not automatically count as non-cognitive language?

A. Because every analogy is literally true in the same sense. B. Because it performs only ritual acts. C. Because analogical predicates can remain truth-apt while qualifying their mode of application. D. Because it denies any referent.

Answer: C. Because analogical predicates can remain truth-apt while qualifying their mode of application.

Explanation: HOW and WHETHER must be separated. Aquinas changes the mode in which a perfection is predicated, not necessarily its truth-aptness. Non-literal reference can be realist; literalism is not the sole form of cognition.

40. Which conclusion best integrates the field without collapsing its theories?

A. Religious utterances require plural analysis: modes of reference and speech-act forces vary, while truth claims remain open to reasons. B. All religious language is meaningless. C. All religious language is literal description. D. Every theory is simply a version of symbolism.

Answer: A. Religious utterances require plural analysis: modes of reference and speech-act forces vary, while truth claims remain open to reasons.

Explanation: Analogy, symbol, negation and indication address reference; assertion, expression, command, ritual and commitment address force. Mitchell's evidential vulnerability, Tillich's participation and Evans' self-involvement can be integrated without pretending their doctrines are identical.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

41. A student writes, "Tillich's symbol is merely a convenient sign for an absent object." What is the best correction?

A. Tillich denies that symbols point beyond themselves. B. Tillich treats every sign as sacred. C. A Tillichian symbol participates in what it signifies and can disclose and transform; it is not merely conventional. D. Tillich says symbols never die.

Answer: C. A Tillichian symbol participates in what it signifies and can disclose and transform; it is not merely conventional.

Explanation: The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.

42. Which correction should be made to the sentence "Scotus says God and creatures are ontologically beings in exactly the same way"?

A. Replace "Scotus" with "Ayer." B. Scotus is defending Maimonidean negation. C. Scotus defends semantic univocity of the concept, qualified by finite/infinite intrinsic modes, not identical ontological being. D. Scotus rejects any common concept.

Answer: C. Scotus defends semantic univocity of the concept, qualified by finite/infinite intrinsic modes, not identical ontological being.

Explanation: This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.

43. Which sentence correctly repairs the claim "Advaita calls Brahman anirvacanīya because Brahman is neither real nor unreal"?

A. *Māyā* is technically *anirvacanīya* as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is *sat* but beyond objectifying speech. B. Advaita calls both Brahman and *māyā* unreal. C. Brahman is an empirically verifiable object. D. *Anirvacanīya* is a synonym for *sphoṭa*.

Answer: A. *Māyā* is technically *anirvacanīya* as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is *sat* but beyond objectifying speech.

Explanation: The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.

44. A student attributes *sphoṭa* and *śabda-nityatva* together to Mīmāṃsā. What is the accurate repair?

A. Mīmāṃsā stresses *vidhi* and *śabda-nityatva*; *sphoṭa* is a grammarian doctrine associated with Bhartṛhari. B. Both belong exclusively to Nyāya. C. *Sphoṭa* belongs to Tillich and *śabda-nityatva* to Austin. D. Both belong exclusively to Advaita.

Answer: A. Mīmāṃsā stresses vidhi and śabda-nityatva; sphoṭa is a grammarian doctrine associated with Bhartṛhari.

Explanation: The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.

45. In answering the 2024 20-mark question marked 10+10, which structure is mandatory?

A. Spend nearly the whole answer defining symbolism. B. Allocate one balanced part to the cognitive/non-cognitive distinction and one to the alleged contradiction with Braithwaite's response. C. Discuss only Braithwaite's biography. D. Treat the marks split as optional metadata.

Answer: B. Allocate one balanced part to the cognitive/non-cognitive distinction and one to the alleged contradiction with Braithwaite's response.

Explanation: Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.

46. Which statement correctly distinguishes Hare and Mitchell?

A. Hare proposes eschatological verification. B. Hare's *blik* is non-factual orientation; Mitchell's partisan models truth-apt, defeasible trust that acknowledges contrary evidence. C. Mitchell accepts Ayer's meaninglessness conclusion. D. Both deny that religious commitments encounter counterevidence.

Answer: B. Hare's blik is non-factual orientation; Mitchell's partisan models truth-apt, defeasible trust that acknowledges contrary evidence.

Explanation: Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.

47. Which claim about symbolism and mysticism is most defensible?

A. Mysticism and symbolism are unrelated. B. Every symbol necessarily culminates in unmediated experience. C. Only Western traditions use symbols as graded practices. D. Symbolism is a normal but non-necessary route; it may be transcended, may arrest in idolatry, or may constitutively shape experience.

Answer: D. Symbolism is a normal but non-necessary route; it may be transcended, may arrest in idolatry, or may constitutively shape experience.

Explanation: The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsanā*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.

48. Which factual statement is safest in a high-scoring answer?

A. Phillips rejected reductionist labelling; Tillich's exception is disputed; and some inter-religious existence-claims remain hard contradictions. B. D. Z. Phillips straightforwardly accepted the label "non-cognitivist." C. Tillich's non-symbolic exception remained unchanged and uncontested. D. Non-literal semantics dissolves every conflict between religions.

Answer: A. Phillips rejected reductionist labelling; Tillich's exception is disputed; and some inter-religious existence-claims remain hard contradictions.

Explanation: The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 14 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

The following are **independent practice models, not official UPSC answer keys**. Question wording, year, number and marks reproduce the verified Paper II bank. Each model follows the directive and mark demand while retaining philosophical distinctions.

2018 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use of language? Discuss.

Demand decoding: “In what sense” requires specified axes of difference, not a hunt for a separate sacred vocabulary. “Discuss” requires both discontinuity and continuity. The answer should compare function, reference, verification, logic and self-involvement.

Model answer

Religious and secular discourse largely use the same words—“father,” “light,” “love,” “path” and “knowledge.” Their difference is therefore primarily one of **use**, not vocabulary.

First, secular assertions commonly describe, predict or instruct concerning empirically identifiable objects. Religious utterances may instead worship, invoke, confess, bless, vow or consecrate. J. L. Austin’s distinction between constatives and performatives clarifies this: “I take refuge in the Buddha” does not merely report a mental state; uttered sincerely in an appropriate setting, it performs a religious commitment. Donald Evans accordingly calls much religious language **self-involving**: its speaker is implicated in a way that the detachable statement “rain is likely” need not imply.

Second, secular reference normally permits ostension and public correction, whereas religious predicates concern a transcendent referent. Ian Ramsey explains this through an ordinary **model**—“father,” “cause,” “good”—stretched by a **qualifier** such as “heavenly,” “first” or “infinitely,” producing disclosure without simple literal identity.

Third, verification differs. Secular claims typically have determinate observational tests; religious claims may appeal to experience, an entire form of life or Hick’s eschatological verification. Yet this does not make every religious sentence non-cognitive: “God exists” is intended as an assertion even when prayers and vows have expressive or commissive force.

Indian traditions reinforce this functional analysis. Mīmāṃsā’s *vidhi* is injunctive—“let it be done”—and mantra functions liturgically; Advaita uses *neti neti* and *lakṣaṇā* where literal predication fails.

Thus religious language is a tradition-formed, symbolically stretched and characteristically self-involving use of ordinary language. It remains parasitic on ordinary meanings and logic; it is not an entirely separate language.

A useful qualification follows: religious and secular uses overlap. A courtroom oath is secular yet self-involving; a historical claim inside scripture may be ordinarily descriptive. The contrast therefore identifies characteristic centres of gravity, not mutually exclusive logical species. That qualification prevents both fideistic isolation and verificationist category error.

Why this earns marks

- Opens with the decisive “use, not vocabulary” thesis.
- Organises comparison through explicit semantic and pragmatic axes.
- Uses Austin, Evans and Ramsey as evidence rather than name-dropping.
- Adds precise Indian parallels: *vidhi*, mantra, *neti neti* and *lakṣaṇā*.
- Preserves the mixed character of religious speech instead of declaring it wholly non-cognitive.

2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: Critically examine Braithwaite’s non-cognitive theory of religious language.

Demand decoding: “Critically examine” requires a fair reconstruction of Braithwaite’s distinct moral-conative account, its argument and examples, followed by strengths, objections, possible reply and a reasoned verdict. It must not be collapsed into Ayer, Hare or Wittgenstein.

Model answer

R. B. Braithwaite's *An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief* (1955) accepts the empiricist challenge that unverifiable theological assertions cannot function as ordinary factual hypotheses, but refuses Ayer's conclusion that religion is simply meaningless. He relocates religious meaning from description to **moral commitment**.

On his account, an assertion such as "God is love" principally declares the speaker's intention to pursue an **agapeistic policy**-a sustained way of life governed by self-giving love. Religious stories support that intention by presenting exemplary patterns and emotionally sustaining narratives. Their practical force does not depend upon their being treated as empirically verified historical or metaphysical reports. Thus religious discourse is non-cognitive in its primary function, yet neither trivial nor merely emotive.

This analysis has three strengths. First, it explains the evident connection between confession and conduct: a creed that never affects action seems religiously defective. Second, unlike Ayer's hostile non-cognitivism, it preserves religion's seriousness and communal narrative. Third, it recognises the **performative** dimension later illuminated by Donald Evans: religious utterances can commit the speaker rather than merely describe an external object.

However, the theory is reductionist. Believers who say "God loves humanity" generally intend both a moral orientation and a claim about reality. Braithwaite preserves the former by deleting the latter, producing what critics call an "atheist's account of religion." Further, if the stories are known not to disclose anything real, it is unclear why their moral policy should command allegiance. A secular humanist could adopt agape without the creed, making specifically religious language dispensable.

Nor are all religious utterances moral policies. Prayer, lament, thanksgiving, mystical negation, creation claims and hopes of resurrection perform different speech acts. Braithwaite therefore wrongly generalises from one important function. His view also differs from Hare's *blik*, a basic world-picture, and from Wittgensteinian meaning-as-use, which does not necessarily reduce use to ethics.

A possible Braithwaitian reply is that he analyses publicly observable religious practice rather than speculative metaphysics, and that narratives embody moral vision more deeply than abstract rules. This reply establishes practical significance but still does not answer the believer's assertoric intention.

The best assessment is therefore mixed: Braithwaite correctly identifies religious language as morally self-involving and narratively sustained, but mistakes a major **illocutionary force** for its whole semantic content. A mixed speech-act account-assertoric, expressive and commissive-retains his insight without his reductionism.

Braithwaite also has difficulty with specifically theological disagreement. If two traditions commend similar love through incompatible stories, his criterion can praise both policies without deciding whether either account of ultimate reality is true. Conversely, a morally troubling policy could remain recognisably religious, showing that religion cannot be defined solely through agape. The theory therefore offers a normative reconstruction more readily than a neutral description of all religion.

Why this earns marks

- Identifies the 1955 text, moral policy, agape and sustaining stories accurately.
- Distinguishes Braithwaite from Ayer, Hare and Wittgensteinian approaches.
- Connects doctrine to Evans' self-involvement while preserving conceptual differences.
- Tests the view against believer intent and the diversity of religious speech acts.
- Ends with a defended mixed-account verdict rather than an unqualified rejection.

2018 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the significance of religious symbols as transcendent referent that mediates into the cultural, spatial and temporal world.

Demand decoding: The directive asks for the **mechanism and significance of mediation**: how a symbol relates transcendence to finite cultural, spatial and temporal forms. Tillich's participation must be central, with examples and a warning against treating symbols as mere signs or literal absolutes.

Model answer

A religious symbol is a finite bearer through which a community apprehends and responds to what it understands as transcendent. Its significance lies not in replacing transcendence with an object, but in **mediating** an otherwise non-ostensible referent into historically inhabitable forms.

Paul Tillich distinguishes a symbol from a sign. A traffic sign conventionally points beyond itself but does not participate in what it indicates. A religious symbol both points and **participates**; it opens levels of reality and of the self otherwise closed, arises from a collective life, possesses transformative power, and may die when it no longer discloses. Thus “God,” cross, temple, *Om*, sacred narrative or pilgrimage-site can organise encounter with ultimate concern without being identical to the ultimate.

This mediation has a **cultural** dimension. Symbols translate transcendence into a community’s myths, images, rituals and ethical memory. The same ultimate concern therefore receives different conceptual and aesthetic forms. Such plurality is not automatically relativism: the bearer is culturally conditioned, while its claim is to disclose more than culture. Ricoeur’s dictum that “the symbol gives rise to thought” captures this interpretive surplus.

It also has a **spatial** dimension. Eliade’s idea of hierophany describes a place or object through which the sacred manifests: a sanctuary, river or axis mundi converts homogeneous space into an oriented sacred geography. Spatial embodiment enables pilgrimage and worship, but risks identifying the transcendent exclusively with one location.

Its **temporal** dimension appears in festivals, commemorations and narratives that make an originating sacred event present to successive generations. Liturgical repetition does not merely recall the past; it re-enacts and renews a community’s orientation.

The chief danger is arrest. When a finite symbol claims ultimacy, Tillich calls the result idolatrous and potentially **demonic**. Conversely, if symbolism is made wholly indeterminate, its referent becomes vague. Tillich attempts to preserve a basis in “being-itself,” though his proposed non-symbolic exception was later modified and remains disputed.

Religious symbols are therefore bridges, not photographs of transcendence. They make ultimate concern culturally intelligible, spatially encounterable and temporally repeatable, while authentic symbolism remains self-transcending and open to criticism.

The mediation is also reciprocal. A community gives a symbol language, ritual location and calendar, but the symbol in turn reshapes communal identity and personal perception. *Om*, for instance, is culturally articulated sound while the *Māṇḍūkya* mapping of waking, dream, deep sleep and *turiya* makes it a contemplative bridge beyond sound. Thus mediation is neither the projection of culture alone nor an unconditioned object dropping into history; it is an interpreted encounter.

Finally, symbolic mediation carries critical significance: because no bearer exhausts transcendence, communities can reinterpret inherited forms when they legitimise domination or exclusion. Fidelity may therefore require reforming a symbol so that it again points beyond itself.

Why this earns marks

- Explains mediation rather than merely listing the uses of symbols.
- Preserves Tillich’s crucial symbol/sign and participation distinctions.
- Develops all three demanded dimensions: cultural, spatial and temporal.
- Uses Ricoeur and Eliade to show interpretive and spatial mechanisms.
- Balances disclosure with idolatry, the demonic and referential-vagueness objections.

2019 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: Discuss whether and how does religious symbolism lead to mysticism.

Demand decoding: The stem contains two obligations: decide **whether** symbolism leads to mysticism and explain **how** the transition occurs. A 20-marker must reconstruct the affirmative route, provide Western and Indian evidence, develop the negative case, and deliver a qualified verdict rather than assuming necessity.

Model answer

Religious symbolism can lead to mysticism when a finite symbol functions as a participatory medium that becomes transparent to, and is finally transcended in, an immediate apprehension of the ultimate. Yet it is neither a necessary

nor an invariably successful route: symbols may arrest consciousness, and some theories deny that mystical experience ever escapes symbolic mediation.

How the affirmative route works. For Paul Tillich, a genuine symbol differs from a sign because it participates in what it signifies and opens levels of reality and self otherwise closed. A sacred image, name or sound therefore does more than convey information; it draws the worshipper into a relationship with ultimate concern. Repeated contemplation can shift attention from the sensible bearer to the depth it mediates. At a further stage, the bearer becomes self-effacing: the symbol is retained as a doorway but not mistaken for the destination. Mysticism names the limiting movement toward immediacy beyond conceptual mediation.

Paul Ricoeur's phrase "the symbol gives rise to thought" explains the interpretive beginning of this process. His "second naïveté" describes a post-critical return in which one inhabits a symbol without crude literalism.

Pseudo-Dionysius supplies its theological ascent: cataphatic names are first affirmed from creatures, then negated apophatically, culminating in the "darkness beyond light," where discursive predicates fall silent. Symbolic affirmation thus educates the mind for mystical unknowing.

Indian evidence makes the sequence especially clear. In *pratīka* or *pratimā upāsana*, a finite support disciplines attention and devotion; it can prepare movement from *saguṇa* worship to apprehension of *nirguṇa* Brahman. The *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*'s treatment of *Om* is a precise model: A-U-M corresponds to waking, dream and deep sleep, while the soundless *amātra* points to *turiya*, the non-dual fourth beyond the articulated symbol. Tantric mantra, *yantra* and *maṇḍala* similarly operate as instruments to be internalised and dissolved. These examples prove not that every symbol causes mystical experience, but that traditions deliberately structure symbols as graded *sādhana*s.

Why the transition may fail. First, literalisation can stop the movement. Tillich calls the absolutisation of a finite bearer idolatry; the "demonic" appears when the conditioned claims ultimacy. A symbol then conceals rather than reveals. Second, Steven Katz's constructivist objection challenges the very notion of unmediated culmination: mystical experiences are shaped from the start by inherited concepts and practices. On this view symbol does not first lead to and then disappear into mysticism; it **constitutes** the kind of mysticism experienced.

Third, symbolic practice is not necessary. *Neti neti*, Zen iconoclasm and apophatic disciplines can proceed by deleting images rather than deepening them. Ethical purification, *manana*, contemplative attention or grace may also be independent routes. Fourth, mystical reports often return to symbols for communication; ineffability does not abolish culturally formed interpretation.

The relation is therefore conditional. Symbolism leads toward mysticism when it combines participation with self-transcendence: *Om* toward the soundless fourth, *saguṇa* toward *nirguṇa*, and cataphatic naming toward apophatic silence. It obstructs when its bearer is literalised. Under constructivism, moreover, "leading to" must be reformulated as "forming." Religious symbolism is consequently a normal and powerful, but non-necessary and non-guaranteed, route to mysticism.

A further distinction is needed between psychological sequence and logical dependence. A devotee may in fact move from image to contemplative absorption, yet that biography alone does not prove that the symbol logically contains mystical knowledge. The tradition must supply disciplines, interpretations and ethical preparation that govern the transition. This explains why the same symbol can become a mystical support for one practitioner, an aesthetic object for another and an idol for a third.

Mystical culmination also need not destroy symbolism socially: the mystic returns to language to teach, and the report again bears cultural form.

Why this earns marks

- Answers "whether" immediately and gives a four-stage account of "how."
- Uses Tillich's participation to establish the causal-semantic mechanism.
- Integrates Ricoeur, Pseudo-Dionysius, *upāsana* and *Māṇḍūkya* as evidence.
- Includes the mandatory negative case: idolatry, Katz, iconoclastic routes and non-necessity.
- Distinguishes symbol as route, symbol as arrest and symbol as constitutive framework.
- Concludes with a precise conditional verdict rather than a simplistic yes/no.

Question: Does religious language carry cognitive content? Elucidate in detail.

Demand decoding: “Does” requires a defended answer; “elucidate in detail” requires a spectrum rather than two boxes. The answer must define cognitive content, examine verification and falsification, compare realist, symbolic, performative and non-cognitive positions, and defend a nuanced conclusion.

Model answer

Religious language carries cognitive content when its utterances purport to say something true or false about reality, but it rarely does so as unqualified literal description. Its actual grammar is plural: a religious sentence may be simultaneously assertoric, analogical or symbolic, expressive and performative. Therefore the correct answer is neither that all God-talk is straightforwardly factual nor that none of it is truth-apt.

The cognitivist case. Believers ordinarily intend “God exists,” “God is good” or “liberation is possible” as claims, not merely feelings. Aquinas preserves this realist intention through analogy. Perfection-terms have a true *res significata*, while their creaturely *modus significandi* is inadequate to God. Analogy of attribution orders creaturely goodness to its source; proportionality permits each subject to possess perfection according to its mode. Thus non-literal predication need not be non-cognitive.

Tillich offers symbolic realism. Symbols participate in the reality they indicate and disclose levels otherwise closed; “God” is not one being but points to being-itself. His disputed proposal that “God is being-itself” is non-symbolic seeks a referential anchor, though the exception was later modified and risks self-reference. Ian Ramsey’s model-and-qualifier likewise stretches an ordinary model toward disclosure without empty equivocation.

The empiricist challenge. Ayer’s verification criterion treats unverifiable metaphysics as literally meaningless. Yet the criterion is arguably neither analytic nor empirically verifiable and excludes many meaningful historical, ethical and theoretical claims. John Hick’s celestial-city parable responds with **eschatological verification**: a claim may be truth-apt now and confirmable at the journey’s end, even if not conclusively falsifiable beforehand.

Antony Flew shifts from verification to falsification. In the invisible-gardener parable, endless qualifications cause a claim to “die” because no conceivable evidence counts against it. R. M. Hare answers with *bliks*, basic world-pictures that matter without being factual hypotheses. Basil Mitchell’s partisan and Stranger better protects cognitivism: trust may survive counterevidence while acknowledging that evidence genuinely counts against it. Religious claims can therefore be defeasible without being decisively falsifiable in this life.

Non-cognitive insights and limits. Braithwaite interprets “God is love” as commitment to an agapeistic moral policy sustained by stories. Wittgensteinian approaches locate meaning in use within a form of life; D. Z. Phillips, however, rejected being described as a reductive non-cognitivist. Austin and Evans reveal prayer, vow and confession as performative and self-involving. These accounts correctly expose functions missed by correspondence tests, but Braithwaite’s reduction misdescribes believers who also assert that God is real.

Advaita provides a further cognitive-but-non-objectifying model. *Neti neti* removes false predicates and *lakṣaṇā* indirectly indicates non-dual reality. Brahman’s ineffability must not be confused with *māyā*’s *anirvacanīyatā*, its inability to be classified as real or unreal. Language can thus convey knowledge eliminatively and indicatively rather than descriptively.

Consequently, religious language has differentiated cognitive content. Assertions remain truth-apt, but their mode may be analogical, symbolic, negative or indicative; other utterances are commissive, expressive or liturgical. A mixed speech-act realism, disciplined by Mitchell’s vulnerability to evidence and by apophatic limits, best preserves both believer intent and the practical depth identified by non-cognitivists.

Cognitive content should also be graded rather than treated as all-or-nothing. A creation claim, a prayer and a symbol do not submit to identical tests, yet each can have inferential consequences and correctness conditions. Public coherence, experiential adequacy, moral consequences and consistency with other beliefs provide cumulative warrant, even where laboratory verification is unavailable. Such broader warrant must remain corrigible; otherwise a widened notion of evidence merely disguises immunity.

The diversity of religious sentences also blocks a single universal criterion. Historical claims inside a creed invite historical evidence; metaphysical claims invite coherence and explanatory comparison; ritual utterances have felicity conditions; mystical indications are judged by whether they remove conceptual error. Differentiated assessment is not

evasion, provided every claim states its relevant standards and remains open to criticism.

Why this earns marks

- Gives a direct, graded thesis and defines the cognitive issue through truth-aptness.
- Treats the field as a spectrum, accurately placing Aquinas, Tillich, Hick and mixed accounts.
- Reconstructs the Ayer-Flew-Hare-Mitchell debate with named parables.
- Uses Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian use without collapsing their positions.
- Adds Advaita while protecting the Brahman/*anirvacanīyatā* distinction.
- Defends a mixed speech-act realism with an explicit evidential qualification.

2021 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

Question: What is non-cognitive theory of religious language? Explain critically in the light of R. B. Braithwaite's views.

Demand decoding: Define non-cognitivism, distinguish its variants, then give Braithwaite the main analytical space. "Critically" requires strengths, internal and external objections, comparison, reply and verdict. The answer must not equate "non-cognitive" with insignificant or meaningless.

Model answer

A non-cognitive theory holds that religious utterances do not primarily assert propositions made true or false by religious facts. They may instead express attitudes, adopt policies, disclose a world-picture, or operate within practices. This family is internally diverse: Ayer calls unverifiable theology meaningless; Hare treats belief as a *blik*; Wittgensteinian accounts stress use; Braithwaite interprets religious assertion as moral intention. Braithwaite's constructive moral-conative theory is therefore not identical with hostile verificationism.

In *An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief* (1955), Braithwaite accepts that statements such as "God is love" cannot be tested like empirical hypotheses. Their central meaning is a declaration of intention to follow an **agapeistic policy**. Religious stories present exemplary patterns and psychologically sustain this policy. Their function can survive even if they are not treated as empirically established descriptions. Religion becomes a practical orientation expressed through a distinctive narrative vocabulary.

This explains several features of religious life. Creed and conduct are internally connected: sincerely affirming divine love commits one to loving action. The account also preserves significance after Ayer's attack, because non-factual does not mean emotively trivial. Further, it anticipates speech-act analysis. Donald Evans' self-involvement shows why religious avowal changes the speaker's practical relation; Austin's performatives explain why vows and confessions are actions, not failed scientific reports.

Nevertheless, Braithwaite narrows religion too sharply. First, he fails the **intentional adequacy** test. A believer who says "God loves us" intends a fact about God as well as a moral commitment. Removing the referential claim yields an "atheist's account of religion." Second, moral dependence becomes obscure: if the narratives do not disclose reality, why should this particular policy command more than secular agape? The religious rationale becomes dispensable.

Third, religion contains heterogeneous speech acts. Petitionary prayer presupposes an addressee; thanksgiving refers to received benefit; creation, karma and resurrection claims have assertoric grammar; mantra and consecration are liturgical. One moral-policy analysis cannot exhaust them. Fourth, rival religions may recommend incompatible policies. Without cognitive criteria, Braithwaite lacks resources to adjudicate their truth or authority.

Comparison sharpens the point. Hare's *blik* is an unfalsifiable orientation, not necessarily a moral intention. Wittgensteinian meaning-as-use embeds speech in an entire form of life; D. Z. Phillips expressly resisted the charge that this reduces religion to non-cognition. Mitchell's partisan preserves truth-aptness by allowing evidence to count against trusting commitment. Hick's eschatological verification further shows that present non-testability need not entail absence of cognitive meaning.

Braithwaite might reply that his task is to identify religion's empirically accessible function, and that narratives embody motivation which bare secular principles lack. This vindicates practical depth but not the deletion of reference. The stronger view is therefore mixed: religious utterances often assert analogically or symbolically while also committing, expressing and transforming. Braithwaite captures the commissive-moral force exceptionally well, but his theory is a partial pragmatics mistaken for a complete semantics.

There is also a normative problem. Braithwaite's emphasis on agape selects a morally attractive essence of religion, but actual religious discourse can sustain ascetic, ritual, juridical or even exclusionary policies. If the theory calls only agapeistic commitment genuinely religious, it becomes revisionary; if it accepts every policy backed by stories, it loses critical discrimination. Cognitive claims about the object, tradition and reasons for obedience may be indispensable to explaining why one policy rather than another is authoritative.

The theory's treatment of stories produces a further tension. Braithwaite can allow a story to motivate without being factually believed, much as fiction can morally educate. But religious communities often distinguish myth, parable and historical testimony, and that distinction affects authority. If all stories are treated only as useful vehicles, their different cognitive claims disappear. If some must be true, non-cognitivism no longer supplies the complete account. Thus narrative function itself points back toward questions of reference and warrant.

Why this earns marks

- Defines the non-cognitive family while differentiating its members.
- Reconstructs Braithwaite through policy, agape and stories in his own terms.
- Uses Austin and Evans to explain, not merely praise, his practical insight.
- Develops four distinct criticisms, including believer intent and adjudication.
- Compares Hare, Wittgensteinian use, Mitchell and Hick accurately.
- Ends with the precise verdict: valuable pragmatics, inadequate total semantics.

2021 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language with special reference to Paul Tillich.

Demand decoding: Explain Tillich's theory, not symbolism generally. Define symbol against sign; present participation, disclosure, collective origin, growth and death; relate God to being-itself; then assess idolatry, referential vagueness and the disputed non-symbolic exception.

Model answer

Paul Tillich treats religious language as symbolic because the object of ultimate concern cannot be captured as one finite object among others. Symbolism is not decorative metaphor and a symbol is not a mere conventional sign; it is a participatory medium of disclosure.

A sign points beyond itself by convention but does not share in the power or reality it indicates. A symbol, by contrast, **participates** in what it symbolises, opens levels of reality otherwise closed, opens corresponding depths of the self, grows from a collective unconscious or communal life, and can flourish or die. A flag, for example, participates in collective identity more deeply than a traffic signal; religious symbols have still greater existential depth.

Applied to theology, names such as Father, Creator or Lord do not literally classify God as a magnified being. They mediate a relation to ultimate concern. Tillich's decisive ontological caution is that God is not "a being," even the highest, but **being-itself** or the ground of being. Literalising a finite image makes it ultimate and hence idolatrous. Tillich's category of the **demonic** names the distortion in which a conditioned bearer claims unconditional status.

Symbolic language has important strengths. It respects transcendence while retaining positive discourse, unlike complete silence. Because symbols open both world and self, it explains why religious speech transforms rather than merely informs. It also clarifies cultural plurality: different communities may mediate ultimate concern through different symbols without each symbol being an exhaustive photograph of reality.

However, participation is obscure: in what precise sense does a word or image share in its referent? If every God-statement is symbolic, reference threatens to become circular or vague. Tillich tried to anchor the theory by treating "God is being-itself" as the one non-symbolic assertion. Yet he modified this position later, and interpreters dispute whether the exception is coherent: it may contradict universal symbolism or merely state its ontological condition.

Aquinas' analogy offers a useful contrast. Analogy seeks ordered semantic content through causal participation; Tillich's symbol stresses existential participation and disclosure. The former risks indeterminacy of proportion, the latter vagueness of referent.

Tillich therefore establishes that religious language is characteristically symbolic: it participates, discloses and transforms while guarding against anthropomorphic literalism. But symbolism remains cognitively defensible only if

symbols are constrained by an identifiable referent, communal criticism and their capacity to point beyond themselves rather than demand worship for their finite form.

Tillich's account also clarifies the life-cycle of symbolism. Because symbols arise within collective experience, their power cannot be manufactured merely by decree; because cultures change, they can cease to disclose and die. This historical feature explains both continuity and reform in religion. It also supplies a test: a living symbol should open depth while referring beyond itself, whereas a dead or demonic symbol either no longer mediates or captures ultimacy for its finite institution.

Why this earns marks

- Defines symbol by Tillich's criteria and explicitly distinguishes it from sign.
- Connects participation to disclosure and transformation.
- Accurately states being-itself, idolatry and the demonic.
- Preserves the disputed status of Tillich's non-symbolic exception.
- Uses Aquinas as a discriminating contrast and reaches a qualified verdict.

2022 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Question: Explain the difference between the cognitivist and non-cognitivist approaches to the religious language with reference to the statement - "God exists".

Demand decoding: Define both approaches and apply each directly to the specified sentence. Comparison must cover truth-aptness, evidence, function and believer intention, ending with a reasoned position rather than an abstract catalogue.

Model answer

The cognitive/non-cognitive distinction concerns **whether** a religious utterance states something true or false, not **how** divine predicates signify. Applied to "God exists," the contrast is therefore between assertion about reality and an alternative practical or expressive use.

For a cognitivist, "God exists" is propositionally truth-apt. Aquinas would treat its predicates through analogical realism: God is not one creature among others, yet causal participation permits genuine knowledge. Hick likewise preserves truth-aptness through eschatological verification: like travellers approaching the celestial city, believers may hold a claim now that could be confirmed at the journey's end. Cognitivism honours ordinary believer intention, but faces Ayer's verification challenge and Flew's question-what evidence would count against it?

Non-cognitivism relocates meaning. For Braithwaite, avowing belief in God principally declares commitment to an agapeistic moral policy supported by religious stories. Hare would regard the belief as a *blik*, a basic way of seeing the world. A Wittgensteinian may examine how "God exists" functions in worship, repentance and hope within a form of life; D. Z. Phillips, however, rejected the suggestion that this must be a reductive denial of truth. Ayer's hostile version goes further and calls the sentence literally meaningless because unverifiable. These positions must not be treated as identical.

Non-cognitive accounts correctly show that religious avowal transforms and commits the speaker. Yet pure reductionism misdescribes someone who intends to claim that God really exists. Conversely, crude cognitivism misdescribes the sentence as a detached scientific hypothesis.

The most adequate analysis is mixed: "God exists" is assertoric, but its predicates may be analogical or symbolic, and its utterance also has expressive and commissive force. Thus practical meaning supplements rather than cancels cognitive content.

The issue is thus not whether conduct matters, but whether practical force replaces or accompanies assertion. Ordinary religious avowal supports the latter reading.

Why this earns marks

- Applies every distinction to the exact sentence in the stem.
- Separates the WHETHER axis from modes such as analogy and symbol.
- Differentiates Ayer, Braithwaite, Hare and Wittgensteinian use.
- Uses Hick and Flew to frame evidence pressure on cognitivism.

- Defends a clear mixed-account conclusion.

2023 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question: Discuss Wittgenstein's view about the non-cognitive nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Present the Wittgensteinian use/form-of-life approach, illustrate it, explain why it is often read non-cognitively, and critically qualify that attribution-especially the D. Z. Phillips caution.

Model answer

A Wittgensteinian approach shifts attention from asking whether an isolated religious sentence pictures an empirical fact to asking how it is **used** within a language-game and form of life. Meaning is governed by grammar embedded in practices, not fixed solely by ostensive reference.

Thus belief in the Last Judgement need not function as a probabilistic prediction comparable to tomorrow's weather. It may organise repentance, hope, fear, worship and the believer's understanding of life and death. Prayer, confession and blessing likewise acquire sense through their places within religious practice. To remove them from this setting and test them only as scientific hypotheses is to misunderstand their grammar.

This approach is called non-cognitive because it resists interpreting all religious discourse as external fact-reporting. It also explains why disagreement between believer and unbeliever may be deeper than disagreement over one observation: they may inhabit different pictures and practical orientations. Yet "meaning is use" does not entail "anything accepted inside a community is true." Language-games remain describable, morally criticisable and connected to other practices.

Two cautions are essential. First, Wittgenstein did not provide one systematic theory reducing theology to attitude; later Wittgensteinians developed different readings. Second, D. Z. Phillips expressly rejected the label "non-cognitivist" and the allegation that he protected religion through fideism. His aim was to clarify religious grammar, not to declare beliefs fictional or meaningless.

The view's strength is contextual sensitivity: it captures self-involvement and prevents category mistakes. Its weakness is possible insulation-if internal use alone settles meaning, external evidence and rival truth-claims may appear irrelevant. Mitchell's defeasible trust offers a corrective by allowing religious commitment to retain its practice while acknowledging counterevidence.

Accordingly, Wittgensteinian analysis reveals that religious language cannot be reduced to detached description; it does not conclusively prove that such language lacks cognitive content.

Why this earns marks

- Explains language-game, grammar, form of life and meaning-as-use.
- Uses the Last Judgement to show how religious use differs from prediction.
- Avoids attributing a crude systematic non-cognitivism to Wittgenstein.
- Includes the required Phillips qualification and fideism objection.
- Gives a balanced verdict with Mitchell as a focused corrective.

2023 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language according to Tillich.

Demand decoding: This repeats the Tillich core but merits a full 15-mark independent model: mechanism, criteria, ontology, strengths, objections and verdict. It should not merely reproduce a definition or call symbols signs.

Model answer

For Paul Tillich, religious discourse is symbolic because finite literal concepts cannot contain the object of ultimate concern. A symbol is not a decorative substitute for a literal description; it is the characteristic medium through which religious reality becomes accessible.

Tillich distinguishes **sign** and **symbol**. A sign refers by convention and can normally be replaced without loss: a red light directs traffic but does not participate in stopping. A symbol points beyond itself while participating in what it indicates. It opens levels of reality otherwise closed, opens corresponding levels of the human self, arises from collective life rather than arbitrary invention, and can grow or die. A national flag's relation to communal identity illustrates participation, though religious symbolism reaches toward ultimacy.

Consequently, “God,” “Father,” “Kingdom,” cross, icon and sacred narrative mediate ultimate concern rather than classify God as a finite object. Tillich refuses to call God the highest being, because that would place God within the totality of beings. God is **being-itself**, the ground of the power of being. Religious symbols disclose this depth and evoke existential transformation; their function is participatory, not merely informational.

The theory explains why symbols are culturally variable yet spiritually serious. A symbol can carry a community’s memory, orient worship and open a depth that literal prose cannot exhaust. It also diagnoses literalism. When a conditioned image claims unconditional validity, it becomes idolatrous; Tillich calls the absolutised finite bearer **demonic**.

Nevertheless, the theory faces a referential problem. “Participation” can appear metaphorical unless criteria identify what the symbol participates in. If all statements about God are symbolic, the assertion that they are symbolic seems itself to require a non-symbolic basis. Tillich proposed “God is being-itself” as the exceptional non-symbolic assertion, but later modified the view, and its exact status remains disputed. The exception may either anchor reference or contradict the universal thesis.

Aquinas’ analogy illuminates the difference. Both avoid univocal anthropomorphism, but Aquinas grounds ordered predication in causal participation and distinguishes *res significata* from creaturely *modus significandi*. Tillich instead stresses existential disclosure and transformation. Analogy risks indeterminacy; symbolism risks vague reference.

Tillich’s achievement is to show how religious language can be non-literal without being empty. It remains viable as symbolic realism when participation is disciplined by a referential anchor, communal interpretation and the symbol’s self-transcending character. A mere sign directs attention; a genuine religious symbol mediates and transforms.

Religious symbolism can also be cognitively discriminating. A symbol has a history, communal grammar and network of implications; not every interpretation is equally admissible. Its adequacy can be tested by coherence with the tradition’s ultimate concern, its capacity to disclose rather than conceal, and its refusal to absolutise the finite. These constraints do not yield scientific verification, but they prevent “symbolic” from becoming a licence for arbitrary meaning.

Why this earns marks

- Reconstructs all major Tillichian criteria of a symbol.
- Makes participation-not resemblance-the mechanism of meaning.
- Explains being-itself, ultimate concern, idolatry and the demonic.
- Handles the non-symbolic exception as disputed rather than settled.
- Uses Aquinas to clarify both the theory’s achievement and its risk.

2024 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Question: Explain the analogical nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Explain why analogy is needed, its two forms, metaphysical basis and technical distinction, then contrast it with Scotus and negation. A 10-marker needs mechanism, example, objection and verdict.

Model answer

Religious predication faces a dilemma. If “good” or “wise” means exactly the same when said of God and creatures, God is anthropomorphically placed within a finite category. If it means something wholly different, God-talk becomes equivocal and inference to God fails. Aquinas proposes **analogy** as ordered similarity-with-difference.

In the **analogy of attribution**, a predicate belongs primarily to one subject and derivatively to another through causal relation. “Healthy” belongs primarily to an animal and secondarily to medicine as a cause of health or complexion as its sign. Applied theologically, creaturely perfections are ordered to God as their source, although the health example illustrates the logic rather than directly defining divine goodness.

In the **analogy of proportionality**, goodness is in God according to the divine mode as goodness is in a creature according to its finite mode. Effects resemble their cause without possessing perfection identically. Aquinas therefore distinguishes the *res significata*, the perfection signified and truly applicable to God, from the *modus significandi*, our creaturely manner of signifying, which is inadequate.

Duns Scotus objects that inference requires a univocal concept of being and pure perfection; otherwise analogy disguises equivocation. His univocity is semantic, not ontological: finite and infinite intrinsic modes preserve the gulf. Aquinas replies that causal participation supplies ordered continuity without placing God in a shared genus. Maimonides' negative way protects transcendence more radically but risks vacuity.

Indian parallels sharpen the choice: Nyāya approximates univocal predication, Advaita's *lakṣaṇā* supplies indirect indication, and *neti neti* supplies negation.

Analogy thus preserves meaningful realism without crude literalism. Its standing weakness is indeterminacy-how is the proportion fixed?-but causal ordering makes it more informative than equivocation and less anthropomorphic than univocity.

Its success therefore depends on real metaphysical participation, not merely verbal resemblance. Without that grounding, the proposed middle way would indeed collapse toward equivocation.

Why this earns marks

- Frames the univocal/equivocal dilemma before presenting the solution.
- Explains attribution and proportionality with the "healthy" example correctly limited.
- Uses *res significata/modus significandi* and causal participation.
- States Scotus' univocity as semantic, not ontological.
- Ends with the exact trade-off between inference, transcendence and indeterminacy.

2024 · Q8(a) · 20 marks (10+10)

Question: Distinguish between cognitivist and non-cognitivist account of religious language. Does the cognitivist account lead to any contradiction? Answer with reference to the philosophical views of R. B. Braithwaite.

Demand decoding: Respect the printed **10+10 split**. Part I must distinguish the two accounts with Braithwaite accurately located. Part II must identify the alleged contradiction/meaning problem confronting cognitivism, assess whether it is genuine, and evaluate Braithwaite's solution. Neither part should swallow the other.

Model answer

Part I - Cognitivist and non-cognitivist accounts (10 marks)

A cognitivist treats religious assertions as truth-apt claims about reality. "God exists" and "God is good" purport to be true or false even if their evidence and mode of predication differ from ordinary empirical sentences. Aquinas' analogical realism preserves reference without univocal anthropomorphism; Hick's eschatological verification regards a present claim as confirmable at the end of the human journey; Mitchell's partisan model treats faith as defeasible trust that recognises adverse evidence.

A non-cognitivist denies that fact-stating is the primary or valid function. The family is diverse. Ayer calls unverifiable theology literally meaningless. Hare's *blik* is an unfalsifiable world-picture. Wittgensteinian approaches investigate use within a form of life, though D. Z. Phillips rejected being labelled a reductive non-cognitivist. R. B. Braithwaite's distinctive moral-conative account interprets a religious assertion as commitment to a moral policy, sustained by religious stories.

For Braithwaite, "God is love" declares an intention to live according to **agape**. Its religious narratives supply models and motivational context; their role need not depend on empirical verification. This view captures the practical and self-involving force of creed. Cognitivism asks, "What reality does the statement describe?" Braithwaite asks, "What way of life does its avowal commit one to?" Yet these may be different dimensions of one utterance rather than mutually exclusive meanings.

Part II - Does cognitivism lead to contradiction? Braithwaite assessed (10 marks)

The pressure on cognitivism arises when a believer asserts both that God's love is factual and that no conceivable suffering could count against it. Flew's invisible gardener exposes the danger: endless qualifications may preserve a sentence verbally while removing every evidential consequence. Together with Ayer's verification challenge, this creates an apparent contradiction between claiming factual meaning and refusing the vulnerability normally required of factual claims. There is also an anthropomorphic tension if finite predicates are applied literally to an infinite God.

Braithwaite avoids these tensions by abandoning metaphysical description. If “God is love” expresses an agapeistic policy, counterinstances do not falsify it as a hypothesis; they test the believer’s resolve. Religious meaning remains empirically visible in conduct. This is a coherent escape from contradiction, but it succeeds by changing the subject from truth to commitment.

The contradiction is not inevitable. First, Ayer’s verification criterion faces a self-application problem and is too narrow. Second, Aquinas distinguishes the perfection signified from the creaturely mode of signifying, avoiding simple logical contradiction in divine predicates. Third, Mitchell allows evidence of suffering genuinely to count against trust without making it decisive; commitment need not equal immunity. Fourth, Hick proposes verification in principle rather than immediate testability.

Braithwaite also under-describes believer intention. Someone may both assert that God exists and commit to agape. Prayer, thanksgiving, creation and afterlife claims cannot all be reduced to moral policy. His theory therefore captures a real **commissive force** but not the whole semantics.

The cognitivist account leads to contradiction only when combined with crude literalism or total evidential immunity. An analogical, defeasible and mixed speech-act cognitivism can remain coherent while incorporating Braithwaite’s insight that religious avowal must transform life.

The phrase “lead to contradiction” must also be handled logically. Unverifiability is not itself a formal contradiction; it is an alleged failure of empirical meaningfulness. Contradiction arises only if the cognitivist simultaneously claims ordinary factual status and denies every condition of possible correction, or predicates mutually incompatible attributes without analogical qualification. This distinction prevents Braithwaite’s empiricist objection from being overstated as a proof of logical inconsistency.

Accordingly, Braithwaite establishes that factuality is not required for every religious function, but he does not establish that factuality is incoherent. His conclusion outruns his empiricist premise unless verificationism is independently defended.

Why this earns marks

- Visibly and substantively obeys the 10+10 allocation.
- Distinguishes a spectrum of non-cognitivism rather than merging them.
- Locates the alleged contradiction in truth-claim plus evidential immunity.
- Explains how Braithwaite escapes the problem and what that escape costs.
- Uses Aquinas, Mitchell and Hick as distinct replies to the contradiction claim.
- Gives a direct verdict: contradiction is conditional, not inherent.

2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: Is religious language symbolic? Give reasons and justification in support of your answer.

Demand decoding: Take a clear yes/no position, rank reasons, justify through Tillich’s criteria and assess limits. The answer must state that symbolic does not mean merely conventional, non-cognitive or wholly devoid of reference.

Model answer

Religious language is substantially symbolic because its transcendent referent cannot be presented as one finite observable object; however, symbolism is best understood as a mode of meaningful reference, not as proof that every religious utterance lacks cognitive content.

Tillich gives the strongest justification. A sign points conventionally, whereas a symbol **participates** in what it indicates, opens levels of reality and self otherwise closed, grows from collective life and can die. Names such as Father, light or ground therefore do not photograph God; they mediate ultimate concern and transform the participant. Literalising them would turn God into a being among beings. Tillich instead speaks of God as being-itself and warns that an absolutised finite symbol becomes idolatrous or demonic.

Second, symbols explain religious language’s existential force. A creed, sacred narrative or *Oṃ* does not merely transfer information. The *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* maps A-U-M onto waking, dream and deep sleep, while the soundless *amātra* points beyond articulated sound to *turīya*. The symbol can therefore disclose and lead beyond itself.

Third, symbolism accommodates cultural plurality: different traditions mediate transcendence through historically shaped forms without requiring that each form exhaust the referent. This supports humility, though it cannot dissolve hard contradictions such as whether a creator exists.

The theory has limits. Participation is difficult to specify, and wholly symbolic theology risks vague reference. Tillich once treated “God is being-itself” as non-symbolic, but later modified this disputed exception. Further, prayers, vows and assertions have different speech acts; “I repent” is performative, while “God exists” retains assertoric intent.

Thus religious language is characteristically symbolic in its mode of reference, but not exclusively symbolic in function. A defensible symbolic realism joins participation with referential discipline and refuses both literalism and reduction to mere sign.

Symbolism is therefore strongest as a qualified semantic thesis: it explains reference under transcendence while leaving room for assertion, performance and negation.

Why this earns marks

- Answers “yes, but” immediately and then ranks three reasons.
- Protects the symbol/sign and participation distinctions.
- Uses *Om-turīya* as evidence for self-transcending symbolism.
- Preserves Tillich’s being-itself caution and disputed exception.
- Qualifies symbolism through mixed speech acts and hard contradictions.

2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Discuss the Advaitic notion of indescribability (*anirvacanīyatā*) in the context of nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Treat *anirvacanīyatā* as a semantic-predicative issue, while preserving the exact distinction: technically it characterises *māyā*/world-appearance as neither real nor unreal; Brahman is ineffable/non-objectifiable but is not indeterminable in that same ontological sense. Explain *neti neti*, *lakṣaṇā*, self-reference and sublation.

Model answer

Advaita challenges the assumption that religious language must describe its ultimate object through ordinary subject-predicate classification. Yet “indescribability” has two distinct senses that must not be collapsed. Brahman is beyond objectifying speech-*avācya*-whereas *anirvacanīya* technically characterises *māyā*, *avidyā* and world-appearance as not classifiable as either absolutely real or absolutely unreal.

Ordinary discourse classifies an object under determinate predicates. The empirical world appears and has transactional validity, so it cannot be simply unreal like a hare’s horn. Yet it is sublated by knowledge of Brahman, so it is not ultimately real. It is therefore *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*, different from both real and unreal, and hence *anirvacanīya*. This is an ontological-semantic claim about the failure of binary predication, not merely a confession that speakers lack information.

Brahman presents a related but different linguistic limit. The Taittirīya formula *yato vāco nivartante*-words turn back-marks its non-objectifiability, while Bṛhadāraṇyaka’s *neti neti* removes every limiting identification. Negation is not nihilism: it denies finite modes, not reality itself. Brahman is *sat*; it is not “neither real nor unreal” in the status assigned to *māyā*.

Advaita nevertheless gives scripture a pedagogical role through **lakṣaṇā**, *indirect indication*. *In tat tvam asi*, *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations-the omniscient causal standpoint of *tat* and the finite embodied standpoint of *tvam*-while retaining consciousness as their common import. Language therefore works eliminatively through *neti neti* and indicatively through *lakṣaṇā**, rather than literally describing Brahman as an object.

A familiar objection is self-reference: “Brahman is indescribable” seems itself to describe Brahman. Advaita replies that such statements regulate and negate objectifying discourse; they function like a thorn that removes another thorn and are themselves sublated after knowledge. Still, critics ask how an indicative sentence can convey a determinate referent without presupposing what it claims exceeds language.

Compared with Maimonides, Advaita shares the *via negativa* but adds a detailed indirect-semantic method. Compared with Aquinas, *lakṣaṇā* resembles analogy in mediating beyond literal sense, though Advaita’s end is non-dual

recognition rather than predication across Creator and creature.

Advaitic indescribability is thus not wholesale silence. It diagnoses the limits of classificatory and objectifying speech, distinguishes *māyā*'s indeterminability from Brahman's ineffability, and assigns language a self-cancelling pedagogical function: remove error, indicate non-duality, and fall silent when knowledge dawns.

This framework also distinguishes Advaita from simple emotivism. Upaniṣadic statements are not expressions of feeling; they claim to remove ignorance and culminate in knowledge. Their success-conditions are transformative and epistemic: whether the apparent plurality is sublated in non-dual recognition. Critics may reject the metaphysics, but they cannot accurately classify the language as merely non-cognitive. Its cognition is indirect, corrective and finally self-transcending.

The resulting theory is neither simple realism nor silence: ordinary predicates fail literally, but disciplined negation and implication preserve a path from hearing scripture to understanding its intended import.

Why this earns marks

- Begins with and sustains the decisive Brahman/*māyā* distinction.
- Defines *anirvacanīya* through *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*, not vague ineffability.
- Explains *neti neti* and *lakṣaṇā* as different semantic operations.
- Uses *tat tvam asi* and *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* precisely.
- Addresses self-reference through the thorn/sublation reply.
- Adds focused comparisons with Maimonides and Aquinas before a graded verdict.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

These six questions are **original practice questions, not UPSC PYQs**. Their solutions are independent learner models rather than official keys.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "Analogy protects transcendence only by sacrificing intelligibility." Examine with reference to Aquinas and Scotus.

Demand decoding: "Examine" requires testing the claim, not merely defining analogy. Explain Aquinas' mechanism, present Scotus' strongest objection, give the Thomist reply and reach a graded verdict.

Model answer

The charge identifies analogy's central risk but overstates its failure. Aquinas introduces analogy because univocal predication threatens anthropomorphism while equivocity destroys knowledge. Analogy aims at ordered, not indeterminate, difference.

In attribution, a term belongs primarily to one subject and secondarily to others through relation; "healthy" applies primarily to an animal and derivatively to medicine as cause or complexion as sign. In proportionality, goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs. Causal participation grounds the ordering: creaturely perfections resemble their source without reproducing its mode. Thus the *res significata* applies truly, while the creaturely *modus significandi* remains inadequate.

Scotus nevertheless presses a powerful semantic objection. If "being" or "good" has no univocal conceptual core, an inference from creature to God equivocates. His certain-and-doubtful argument shows that one may be certain God is a being while doubtful whether finite or infinite; hence a neutral concept precedes the intrinsic modes. This is semantic, not ontological, univocity.

The Thomist replies that causal dependence, rather than membership in a common genus, supplies continuity. Yet the reply must explain how the proportion is fixed without presupposing knowledge of God. Analogy therefore preserves some intelligibility but not complete conceptual transparency.

A defensible position combines an analogical centre with a minimal univocal content necessary for inference and an apophatic limit on adequacy. Analogy does not sacrifice intelligibility; it accepts **qualified intelligibility** as the price of speaking realistically about transcendence.

The dispute also shows that intelligibility is purpose-relative. Demonstrative inference needs conceptual stability, whereas worship and contemplation need protection against reducing God to a classifiable object. Scotus prioritises the former and Aquinas the latter without abandoning it. A successful doctrine must therefore specify enough common content to license reasoning while denying that the human concept exhausts the divine mode.

Why this earns marks

- Converts the quotation into a precise intelligibility-versus-transcendence problem.
- Uses both forms of analogy and the technical signification distinction.
- Gives Scotus' certain/doubtful argument and semantic qualification.
- Presents the Thomist reply before judging it.
- Concludes with a graded, defensible synthesis.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Can religious utterances be performative without ceasing to be cognitive? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Define performative and cognitive, use concrete religious speech acts, reject the false either/or, and state conditions under which assertion and self-involvement coexist.

Model answer

Yes. "Performative" identifies what an utterance does; "cognitive" identifies whether it also carries truth-apt content. The categories concern different dimensions and need not exclude each other.

J. L. Austin distinguishes the locutionary content of words from their illocutionary force and perlocutionary effects. "I take refuge in the Buddha," "I baptise you," a vow or *samkalpa* performs an act under appropriate conditions. Donald Evans calls religious language self-involving because such avowals constitute relationships and commit conduct.

Yet their success depends upon cognitive presuppositions. Baptism presupposes a community, authority and beliefs about the rite; thanksgiving presupposes a benefactor and benefit; prayer normally presupposes an addressee. Even "God is love" may both assert something about God and commit the speaker to agape. Braithwaite correctly identifies the moral-commissive dimension but reductionistically treats it as primary meaning at the expense of believer intent.

Conversely, not all religious discourse has the same force. "God exists" is more directly assertoric; "May peace prevail" is optative; confession is expressive and performative; Mīmāṃsā *vidhi* is injunctive. A mixed speech-act analysis maps these differences instead of forcing every sentence into fact-report or non-fact.

Cognitive content must still face evidential discipline. Mitchell's partisan shows that commitment can survive counterevidence while acknowledging that it counts. Thus performance should not become immunity.

Religious utterances can therefore be assertoric, symbolic and performative simultaneously. Their self-involvement enriches cognition by showing its practical import; it cancels cognition only when a theorist, such as a strict moral-conative reductionist, stipulates that no reality is asserted.

The relevant distinction is between the proposition expressed and the force with which it is uttered. One proposition may be asserted, confessed or recited ironically; one religious act may include several propositions. Mapping both levels is philosophically superior to assigning each sentence one permanent category independent of context.

Why this earns marks

- Separates semantic truth-aptness from illocutionary force.
- Uses Austin, Evans, Braithwaite and Mitchell for distinct analytical jobs.
- Supplies varied examples rather than treating all religious speech alike.
- Includes Mīmāṃsā *vidhi* as an accurate Indian application.
- Gives a direct yes-with-conditions verdict.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Compare the via negativa of Maimonides with Advaita's *neti neti*. Do they end in meaningful discourse or silence?

Demand decoding: Compare grounds, methods and permissible positive speech; include Maimonides' attributes of action and Advaita's *lakṣaṇā*. "Do they" demands an evaluated conclusion about meaningfulness, self-reference and

silence.

Model answer

Maimonides and Advaita use negation to prevent finite predicates from objectifying the ultimate. Both deny that ordinary positive language captures its referent; neither, however, simply begins and ends with mute scepticism. Their negative methods regulate discourse and prepare distinct forms of indirect understanding.

In *Guide for the Perplexed* 1.50-60, Maimonides rejects positive essential attributes of God. To say that God possesses wisdom as creatures do would compromise divine simplicity and introduce plurality into the divine essence. Legitimate speech therefore takes two forms. **Negations** deny limitations-God is not ignorant or powerless-while **attributes of action** describe effects: God is called merciful because divine action appears merciful, not because a creature-like quality inheres in God. Negation can progressively remove error, although the more determinate one's language becomes, the greater the anthropomorphic danger.

Advaita's *neti neti*, associated with Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6, similarly removes every finite identification of Brahman. The Taittirīya formula *yato vāco nivartante* marks the failure of objectifying speech. Yet Brahman is not declared unreal. It is *sat* and self-revealing consciousness; negation removes superimpositions rather than annihilating the referent.

Advaita also develops a positive-indirect resource absent in the same form from Maimonides: **lakṣaṇā**. *In tat tvam asi*, bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā *discards incompatible connotations of tat and tvam while retaining consciousness as common import. Language thus indicates non-duality by correcting literal meaning. Moreover, anirvacanīyatā properly belongs to māyā as sad-asad-vilakṣaṇā**; it must not be used to make Brahman neither real nor unreal.

Both theories face vacuity and self-reference. Unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God or Brahman from nothing. "The ultimate is indescribable" also appears to describe it. Maimonides answers partly through action-language and the cognitive value of removing false beliefs. Advaita answers pedagogically: scripture and negation are thorns used to remove ignorance and are themselves sublated when direct knowledge arises.

The traditions nevertheless terminate differently. Maimonidean silence protects an irreducible Creator-creature distinction; attributes of action sustain ethical and liturgical discourse without disclosing essence. Advaitic silence follows non-dual recognition in which the objectifying subject-object structure is itself overcome; *lakṣaṇā* plays a stronger soteriological role.

They therefore end neither in ordinary positive description nor in meaningless silence. Negation has determinate content insofar as it excludes error; action-language and indirect indication guide practice and understanding. Yet their success depends on a referential context supplied by tradition and experience. Without that context, the vacuity objection remains forceful.

Their ethical consequences also differ in emphasis. Maimonides' action-language allows imitation of divine mercy without claiming insight into essence. Advaita's negation undercuts egoic identification and supports liberation through knowledge. In both, semantic restraint has practical purpose: it disciplines the speaker as much as it limits propositions. This self-transformative function helps explain why disciplined silence can remain meaningful rather than amount to absence of thought.

Why this earns marks

- Compares metaphysical grounds rather than merely noting shared negation.
- Uses Maimonides' negations and attributes of action precisely.
- Adds Advaita's *lakṣaṇā*, sublation and soteriological purpose.
- Protects the Brahman/*māyā* and ineffability/*anirvacanīyatā* distinctions.
- Addresses both vacuity and self-reference before a graded verdict.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "The meaning of religious language is exhausted neither by truth-conditions nor by use." Critically discuss.

Demand decoding: Test a synthetic claim. Reconstruct what truth-condition approaches and use theories each explain, show what each misses, compare major thinkers without homogenising them, and defend or reject a mixed account.

Model answer

The statement is persuasive because religious discourse is heterogeneous. Truth-conditions are necessary for claims believers intend as assertions; use is necessary for understanding prayers, vows, confession and life-orientation. Neither alone exhausts its semantics and pragmatics.

Cognitivism begins from believer intent. "God exists," "God is good" and "liberation is possible" purport to describe reality. Aquinas' analogical realism shows that truth-aptness need not require univocal literalism: the perfection signified applies while the creaturely mode of signification is inadequate. Hick's eschatological verification similarly holds a claim truth-apt now although confirmable only at the journey's end. Mitchell's partisan adds evidential discipline: trust may persist while contrary evidence genuinely counts.

Yet truth-conditions alone under-describe religious life. Austin shows that utterances act; Evans' self-involvement explains why "I take refuge" constitutes commitment. Ramsey's model-and-qualifier shows how familiar words evoke disclosure. Religious language can be expressive, commissive, injunctive or liturgical as well as assertoric. Mīmāṃsā *vidhi* makes the point sharply: sacred language often says "let it be done," and mantra functions as an instrument within ritual.

Use theories provide this missing context. Wittgensteinian attention to language-games explains why Last Judgement belief may organise repentance rather than function as a dated forecast. D. Z. Phillips, however, rejected being treated as a reductionist non-cognitivist. Internal grammar must not be equated automatically with denial of truth.

Braithwaite demonstrates both the strength and danger of privileging use. Interpreting "God is love" as commitment to agape captures conduct and narrative motivation. But if the believer also asserts divine reality, moral-policy reduction is intentionally inadequate. Hare's *blik* likewise preserves significance but gives up factual vulnerability; Ayer goes further and calls unverifiable theology meaningless. These non-cognitivisms are not one theory.

A mixed account also needs safeguards. If every practice immunises its own claims, language-game analysis risks fideism. If every symbol is unconstrained, Tillichian participation risks vague reference. Flew's gardener therefore remains relevant: religious assertions must specify how reasons and counterevidence bear upon them, even when no single test is decisive.

The best conclusion is layered. Mode of reference may be analogical, symbolic, negative or indicative; illocutionary force may be assertion, prayer, promise or command; practical meaning occurs within forms of life. Truth-conditions do not exhaust use, and use does not erase truth. Religious language is most accurately treated as a family of speech acts whose realist claims remain defeasible and whose non-literal forms require referential discipline.

The synthesis should not become an indiscriminate pluralism of meanings. Context determines which force is primary, and some utterances can fail: a vow may be insincere, a factual claim false, a symbol dead, or a prayer conceptually incoherent. Success-conditions differ without disappearing. This allows philosophical evaluation across practices while respecting their internal grammar.

It therefore preserves both contextual sensitivity and standards of assessment.

Why this earns marks

- Builds the answer around the exact "neither/nor" proposition.
- Uses Aquinas, Hick and Mitchell to differentiate cognitive realism.
- Uses Austin, Evans, Ramsey and Mīmāṃsā to analyse practical force.
- Preserves Phillips' caution and distinguishes Braithwaite, Hare and Ayer.
- Imposes evidential and referential safeguards on the mixed conclusion.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Evaluate the proposition that theories of religious language determine the possibility and limits of religious pluralism.

Demand decoding: "Evaluate" requires showing the semantic-to-pluralism mechanism, comparing literal, analogical, symbolic and apophatic routes, using Hick and Indian resources, identifying conflicts that semantics cannot dissolve, and issuing a balanced verdict.

Model answer

Theories of religious language do not by themselves decide whether every religion is true, but they determine how rival truth-claims are compared, what counts as contradiction, and how much cognitive access any tradition can claim. The route is: **semantics -> epistemic access -> status of rival descriptions -> exclusivist or pluralist possibilities**. Language theory therefore sets the possibility and the limits of pluralism.

Univocal literalism and pressure toward exclusivism. If personal, creator, omniscient or salvific predicates apply directly and in the same determinate sense, rival claims become straightforwardly commensurable. “Ultimate reality is a personal creator” and “there is no personal creator” appear flat contradictions; at most one is true in the relevant respect. This does not logically force intolerance, but it naturally supports epistemic exclusivism. Scotus’ semantic univocity is more careful than crude literalism because finite/infinite intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference, yet its strength-clear inferential content-also makes conflict harder to redescribe as merely perspectival.

Analogy, symbolism and apophysis as pluralist openings. Aquinas’ analogy limits creaturely *modus significandi* while retaining a true *res significata*. Different traditions might then predicate one reality through partial, non-exhaustive modes. Tillich’s symbols are culturally generated bearers that participate in and disclose ultimate concern. Because no finite symbol may claim ultimacy without becoming idolatrous or demonic, symbolic theology creates principled humility. Maimonidean negation and Advaita’s *neti neti* go further: no positive finite formulation exhausts the ultimate. Such approaches make personal and impersonal descriptions potentially mode-relative rather than automatically contradictory.

Yet each pluralist opening has a cost. Analogy may be indeterminate; symbol may lack a clear referential anchor; negation may become vacuous. If traditions cannot say enough about the common referent to identify it, pluralism risks uniting them around an empty abstraction.

Hick’s hypothesis exposes the semantic foundation. Hick calls the Real *an sich* transcategorical: personal/impersonal, one/many and purposive/non-purposive do not apply literally. Traditions encounter phenomenal *personae* and *impersonae*-such as Yahweh, Kṛṣṇa or Brahman-through culturally conditioned forms. This is fundamentally a thesis about predication. It allows diverse religions to be responses to one Real, but the vacuity objection is severe: if no substantial predicate applies, how is the Real distinguished from nothing, made worthy of worship, or used to criticise destructive religious phenomena?

Indian resources refine the bridge. Advaita’s distinction between *nirguṇa* Brahman and *saguṇa* forms gives a metaphysical structure for one ultimate and many devotional descriptions, later supporting Vivekananda’s pluralist orientation. Jain *anekāntavāda* and *syādvāda* provide a logical rather than purely apophatic resource. Prefixing claims with *syāt* locates them “in a certain respect”; *saptabhaṅgī* and *nayas* specify standpoint, making reconciliation more disciplined than an appeal to unknowability. R̥gvedic “one referent, many names” similarly marks a semantic distinction, though it cannot simply be imposed on traditions that deny a common referent.

Limits that semantics cannot remove. Non-literal language can soften some conflicts, especially personal versus impersonal descriptions or different symbols of ultimacy. It cannot erase every existence-claim. Either a creator exists or does not in the same respect; either individual post-mortem survival occurs or it does not; doctrines of incarnation and non-incarnation may remain incompatible. Moral conflicts also cannot be dissolved by calling every rule symbolic. A responsible pluralism routes hard contradictions, grades claims and permits criticism.

Further, language is not the only determinant. Historical revelation claims, religious experiences, institutions, power and moral fruits also shape pluralism. Semantic openness creates possibility, but evidence and ethics determine credibility. A fully non-cognitive view may avoid truth-conflict only by eliminating the truth-claims religions themselves make, which is not genuine reconciliation.

The proposition is therefore substantially correct but not exhaustive. Univocal literalism raises the cost of pluralism; analogical, symbolic and apophatic semantics render partial and mode-relative truth intelligible. Hick demonstrates that pluralism rests upon limits of predication, while Jain standpoint logic shows how those limits can be specified. But semantics establishes a space for pluralism, not universal harmony: hard contradictions, evidential assessment and moral criticism remain.

Why this earns marks

- States and follows the full semantics-to-pluralism causal chain.
- Evaluates univocity, analogy, symbol and negation through their trade-offs.
- Shows why Hick’s pluralism is itself a theory of predication.

- Uses Advaita and Jain standpoint logic as distinct, non-decorative resources.
- Separates mode-relative descriptions from hard existence-claims.
- Qualifies linguistic determination through evidence, ethics and history.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: “Religious language is neither literal description nor disguised silence.” Critically assess this claim through analogy, symbol, negation and non-cognitive theories.

Demand decoding: Organise the answer across the HOW and WHETHER axes. Explain how analogy, symbol and negation seek a middle position; compare cognitive and non-cognitive theories; test anthropomorphism, indeterminacy, vacuity and reductionism; defend a final account.

Model answer

The claim expresses the central ambition of theories of religious language: to avoid anthropomorphic literalism without making transcendence unsayable. Its plausibility depends on keeping two questions distinct. **HOW** do finite words refer-univocally, analogically, symbolically or negatively? **WHETHER** do the resulting utterances state truths or instead express policies, attitudes and practices? Conflating these axes falsely equates non-literal speech with non-cognition.

Why literal description is inadequate. Ordinary predicates are learned from finite objects. Applied univocally, “God is wise” risks representing God as a magnified person within a common genus. Tillich therefore rejects God as the highest being and speaks of being-itself; Advaita denies that Brahman is an object of classificatory consciousness. Yet complete equivocity would prevent inference and worship, so a mediating account is required.

Aquinas’ analogical realism. Analogy of attribution orders secondary instances to a primary source; the “healthy” animal/medicine example displays this structure. Analogy of proportionality says goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs. Causal participation supports similarity, while *res significata* and *modus significandi* distinguish true perfection from creaturely expression. Analogy therefore makes non-literal propositions cognitively meaningful. Its weakness is indeterminacy. Scotus argues that valid inference requires a semantically univocal concept of being; finite/infinite intrinsic modes can then preserve ontological difference. A workable analogy may need such minimal conceptual continuity.

Tillich’s symbolic realism. A symbol differs from a sign because it participates, opens reality and self, transforms, arises collectively and can die. Religious symbols mediate ultimate concern without identifying a finite image with God. Their self-transcendence protects against literalism; their absolutisation becomes idolatrous or demonic. However, “participation” can be vague. Tillich’s proposal that “God is being-itself” is non-symbolic sought an anchor, but he later modified it and its coherence remains disputed. Symbol avoids silence only if the referent constrains interpretation.

Negation and indication. Maimonides rejects positive essential attributes but permits negations and attributes of action. *Neti neti* removes limiting superimpositions, while Advaita’s *lakṣaṇā* indirectly indicates non-dual import. In *tat tvam asi*, *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness. This shows that apophasis need not be mute: it can eliminate error and guide recognition. Still, unlimited negation risks vacuity and self-reference. Advaita’s reply-that language is a thorn which removes a thorn and is sublated-explains pedagogy but leaves critics asking how the referent is initially fixed. Brahman’s ineffability must also remain distinct from *māyā’s anirvacanīyatā* as neither absolutely real nor unreal.

The WHETHER question and non-cognitive theories. Ayer turns unverifiability into literal meaninglessness, but his criterion is too narrow and self-problematic. Flew asks what could falsify divine-love claims. Hare’s *bliks* preserve orientation without factual status; Mitchell’s partisan preserves defeasible truth by acknowledging counterevidence; Hick’s celestial city preserves verification in principle.

Braithwaite avoids disguised silence by reading “God is love” as commitment to agape sustained by stories. He captures practice but reduces believer intent: religious persons usually assert reality as well as policy. Wittgensteinian use within a form of life illuminates prayer, repentance and Last Judgement belief, though D. Z. Phillips rejected reductionist non-cognitivist labelling. Austin and Evans show why vows and confessions are performative and self-involving, but performance need not cancel assertion.

The alternatives reveal symmetrical failures. Literalism buys clarity by domesticating transcendence. Pure apophasis buys purity by risking emptiness. Strict non-cognitivism buys practical significance by sacrificing intended reference.

The best account is therefore a disciplined **mixed speech-act realism**: truth-apt claims whose mode is analogical, symbolic, negative or indicative; practical forces that are expressive, commissive and liturgical; and evidential vulnerability modelled by Mitchell rather than absolute immunity.

Religious language is thus neither literal description nor disguised silence when three conditions hold: semantic continuity sufficient for reference, apophatic humility about adequacy, and practical use open to rational and moral criticism. Without those conditions, analogy becomes equivocation, symbolism vagueness, negation vacuity and commitment reductionism.

Why this earns marks

- Structures the entire assessment through the HOW/WHETHER distinction.
- Reconstructs analogy, symbol and negation with their exact mechanisms.
- Uses Scotus, Maimonides and Advaita to test semantic continuity and limits.
- Differentiates Ayer, Flew, Hare, Mitchell, Hick, Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian use.
- Integrates Austin/Evans without inferring that performance cancels cognition.
- Ends with three explicit conditions for a defended middle position.